

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES

SOLOMON'S CANTICLE OF CANTICLES.

PREFACE.

This book is called the Canticle of Canticles, that is to say, the most excellent of all canticles: because it is full of high mysteries, relating to the happy union of Christ and his spouse; which is here begun by love; and is to be eternal in heaven. The spouse of Christ is the Church: more especially as to the happiest part of it, viz. perfect souls, every one of which is his beloved; but above all others, the immaculate and ever blessed Virgin mother. Ch. --- The bridegroom is Christ, as God and man. His praises and those of his spouse are recorded by various speakers.

Solomon has given us three works; for beginners, the more advanced, and the perfect; as the philosophers teach ethics, physics, and metaphysics. All the holy Scriptures contain spiritual food, but they are not all fit for every person.

Heb. v. 13. With what humility ought we not, therefore, to read this most perfect and mystical canticle, as the sentiments of spiritual love are expressed in the same words as that of worldlings, and we are more inclined to follow our own judgment and carnal notions! W. --- None, therefore, should dare to peruse this work, who has not mastered his passions, having his conversation in heaven.

H. --- The Jews would not allow any to read it before the age of thirty. Orig. and S. Jer. --- Some of the fathers and commentators have even asserted that the mystical sense is the only one which pertains to this book, (Theod.

Durham. T.) and it is certainly the true and principal one, though allusion may be made to the marriage of Solomon with Pharaoh's daughter, (C. Bossuet. D.) or with a Tyrian princess, (c. iv. 8.

and 3 K. xiii. 5.) or with Abisag. Rabbins. --- Grotius shews the corruption of his own heart in his impure comments, as Theodorus, of Mopsuestra, is blamed by the second Council of Const. iv. a.

68. The name of God never, indeed, occurs; as he is represented under the idea of the bridegroom, &c. and the piece is allegorical. It might be divided into seven scenes, or nights, as the marriage feast lasted so long. Gen. xxix. 22.

During this time the bridegroom saw his spouse seldom, and with great reserve, (C.) as was the custom with the Lacedemonians. Plut. in Lyc. --
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We might also refer all to six nights, or to the six ages of the Church, conformably to the system of De la Chetardie and Bishop Walmesley on the Apocalypse. --- I. Age. C. i. 2. marks the ascension of Christ, and the propagation of Christianity; v. 4. 5. persecutions; v. 6. 7. vocation of the Gentiles; v. 12. protection granted by Christ. II. C. ii. 3. peace under Constantine; v. 11. 17.

troubles excited by Arius. III. C. iii. 1. irruption of barbarians; v. 4. does not overturn the Church; v. 6. they are converted; v. 11. and Christ is more glorified, as Apoc. xix. IV. C. iv. 5.

the Latin and Greek Churches; v. 8. the Chaldees, lions, and Greeks, leopards, (Dan.) are converted; the Turks obtain dominion; v. 12. the Greek schismatics cut off: v. 16. the Church is persecuted, but protected. V. C. v. 2. Dew marks the cooling of charity, (S. Aug.) when Luther appeared; c. vi. 3. yet the Church triumphs, particularly after the Council of Trent. VI. C. vi. 9.

after the sounding of the sixth trumpet, the Jews are converted, and adorn the Church, in spite of antichrist's power; v. 11. she addresses the synagogue, v.

12. C. viii. 2. obtains leave to go into the house of her mother, as the apostles were of Jewish extraction; v. 7. the constancy of the martyrs appears; (see Rondet.) v. 8-14. the Church pants for her speedy union with her beloved.

We may justly admire her authority, in preserving this and the former work of the canon, notwithstanding the internal and external evidence,

and the ill use made of them by infidels, which seemed to militate against them. The Prot.

Chateillon styles this "a wicked book." Several passages may, no doubt, be abused by a corrupt heart: but what is there so holy, which may not be perverted? When we meditate on this canticle, we ought to remember the admonition given by the Church in the Mass: "Let hearts be on high;" and Oh!

that all might answer with truth: "We have them to the Lord!"

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 1

CHAPTER I.

Canticles. Heb. shir hashirim asher Lishlomo, "the Canticle of Canticles which is for (H.) or according to Solomon," (M.) dictated to him by the Holy Ghost.

Ver. 1. Let. Heb. yishakeni, (H.) "kiss or instruct me," as if to insinuate the we must raise our thoughts from carnal to spiritual things. --- The. Heb. "kisses."

--- His mouth. Others I reject. M.

--- The synagogue prays for Christ's coming, as the Church does for his glorious appearance. W.

--- The figures of the law and predictions afford not satisfaction; only the Messiah can bring it to mankind. Orig. --- They shall all be taught by God. Jo.

vi. 45. Heb. i. 2. H. --- Breasts. Heb.

also, "loves." But the former is the primary signification of (M.) dodec. Christ, in his divine and human nature, is the source of all our good. His graces are manifested. He instructs and feeds us with the truths contained in Scripture, and in tradition, (H.) or in the Old and New Testament.

Ven. Bede, &c. --- Spiritual delights are to be preferred before all terrestrial ones. From the incarnation of Christ, and sanctification of man, all other graces proceed. T. --- At first the spouse speaks to the bridegroom in the third person, to show her respect, though he was certainly present. Her companions attend her. C. --- Wine. All seem to agree that these words are addressed to the bridegroom: which shews that they must be understood in the mystical sense.

H.

**Ver. 2. Ointments. The bosom used to be perfumed. Athen. xv. 5. and
xv. 14. ---**

Thy name.

Thou thyself. The preaching of the gospel produced a wonderful change in the world. 2 Cor. ii.

15. C. --- The Church honours the name of Jesus on the second Sunday after the Epiphany. A.

Butler, p. 130. H. --- Thee. The martyrs and Christian virgins are inflamed with divine love.

Ver. 3-4. To, &c. is in the Sept.; but not in Heb. or Complut. C. --- Grace must draw, and then people will run. Jo. vi. 44. and xii. 32. Phil. iii. 12. S. Amb.

Bossuet. --- Rooms. Where there is abundance of wine and ointments. The extraordinary favours of heaven are not granted to all.

Matt. xiii. 11. C. --- Righteous. The apostles, and faithful souls, (H.) and all who form a right judgment of things, (M.) having their thoughts, works, and actions composed. T. --- Black. Or brown. v. 5. H. --- The Egyptians were of a less fair complexion, and she had been exposed to the sun. v. 5. C. --- The synagogue gloried in her advantages; but the Gentiles being chosen by Christ, obtain the palm. Theod. --- Though outwardly afflicted, the Church is inwardly fair. W.

--- Cedar. Or of the Arabs, who dwelt in tents, made of black goat's hair. C. ---

The tents of the eastern kings were equal in magnificence to our palaces.

Bernier, Valle, &c.

Ver. 5. Altered. Heb. "looked upon me," (Prot.) or "darted his rays at me." Mont.

H. --- The Church of the Gentiles was quite disfigured before Christ chose it.

Persecutors afterwards strove to tarnish its beauty, but in vain. --- Vineyard.

My face (C.) and person I have not regarded, while I was attentive to serve others. H. --- Pastors, who are chosen against their will, sometimes pay so much attention to the welfare of their flock, that they neglect their own interior, and fall into small faults, which Christ will know how to excuse and pardon.

Ezec. xxxiii. 2. S. Bern. ser.

xxx. C.

Ver. 6. Liest. Heb. "makest thy flock to rest." Prot. H. --- Mid-day. She represents herself and her beloved as guarding flocks, which were usually driven into some shady place during the heat of the day, when the shepherds took their innocent recreations. --- Wander. Sept. Prot. But marginal note has,

"as one that is veiled," which was the mark of a common woman. Gen.

xxxviii. 14. The Gentile Church is eager to be guided by the one true Shepherd, and adheres to him with the greatest fervour, (C.) during the heat of persecution. Cassiod. --- We ought to imitate the solicitude of the spouse, and hide ourselves under the shadow of the cross when we are tempted. Isai. xxv.

4. C.

Ver. 7. If. Christ comforts his Church. W. --- He doubts not of her fidelity. M. ---

But the very insinuation, which she had made, causes him to give her this sort of rebuke. God is jealous. Ex.

xxxiv. 14. He punishes the smallest faults. The spouse perceives this, and runs towards him. ---

Thyself. He who is ignorant of himself, must be so likewise of God, (C.) and will be sentenced to feed goats. S. Jer. ep. xxii. ad Eustoc. --- Kids. Which had been detained at home. They will naturally seek their mothers. All creatures will raise the soul to God. Job xii. --- Shepherds.

Though in the midst of a perverse generation of idolaters and philosophers, the Church will continue steadfast. M.

Ver. 8. Company. Heb. "mare." Such were preferred, as more gentle and swift.

Pharao had probably made his son-in-law a present of a magnificent chariot.

Theocritus (xviii.) compares the beauty of Helena to a Thessalian horse in a chariot, so that this idea is not low. Gen. xlv. 14.

Os. x. 11. C. --- Horsemen. Prot. "horses." H. --- Heb. susa. Sept. e ippas means also "cavalry,"

as well as a mare. The Church has nothing to fear. M.

Ver. 9. As, &c. Heb. "with rows of jewels, thy neck with chains of gold." Prot. ---

Sept. here read like the Vulg. c instead of b before thurim, which signifies chains, (v. 10. H.) as well as turtles. We cannot say that this bird has cheeks. C.

--- It is an emblem of the Church mourning, and ever true to her beloved, (Orig.

&c.) who bestows a variety of graces on different people. 1

Cor. xii. 4. C.

Ver. 11. While. The Church meditates on his passion and resurrection.
W. ---

Repose. Or bed.

**Thus our Saviour was treated. Matt. xxvi. 7. Lu. vii. 37. C. --- Odour.
The virtues of the Church please him. M. --- The saints, before and
since his coming, pray with all earnestness.**

Apoc. v. 8.

Ver. 12. Abide. Heb. adds, "all night." Christ remained nine months in the virgin's womb. C.

--- The faithful discover him in both the Testaments, (H.) and meditate on his sufferings. Myrrh is a bitter but odoriferous liquor.

Ver. 13. Cyprus. A shrub with leaves like the olive-tree, and fruit growing in clusters, of a very agreeable smell. See Pliny, xii. 24. Christ has given us his sacred blood on the cross, and in the blessed Eucharist. M.

Ver. 14. Behold. Christ praiseth his spouse. W. --- Doves. Sharp-sighted, and reddish. Gen.

xlix. 12. The Holy Ghost came upon Christ in the form of a dove. Matt. iii. 16.

We must imitate his simplicity, (Matt. x. 16.) and have a pure and single eye, or intention, (Matt. vi. 22. C.) inviolably to please God. Orig. --- The Church decides matters of controversy, without any mistakes. M.

Ver. 15. Behold. The spouse makes a return of praise, and thanksgiving for her repose, to Christ.

W. --- The corporal beauty of Solomon or of our Saviour is not fully ascertained; but their inward perfections are often proclaimed. --- Flourishing.

Heb. "green." Sept. "shaded." Est. i. 5. ---

This bed was the womb of the blessed Virgin, the cross, or any faithful soul. S.

Bernard says it is a monastery, retired and adorned with all virtues. C.

**Ver. 16. Beams. Prelates. --- Rafters. Virtuous subjects. M. --- Cypress.
The are both odoriferous and incorruptible. The cypress has leaves
from top to bottom, and grows not so large as the cedar. Pliny, xii. 17.**

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. I am. The spouse compares herself to a lily, as she is the fairest flower on the bed, (C.) or Christ may here speak. W. Isa. xi. 1. Orig. --- He praises himself first, that his spouse may hear her own eulogy. M.

Ver. 2. Thorns. The bridegroom enhances the praise of his spouse. The Church, surrounded by infidels and persecutors, maintains her beauty and station. Heretics, &c. are no better than thorns.

Orig. C. --- The Church excels all other societies. In her communion the innocent are preferred before sinners, and among the former, the blessed Virgin surpasses all.

Ver. 3. As. The Church praises Christ, resting secure under his protection. W.

Ver. 4. Cellar. This was not under ground. Homer (Od. b. 237.) places the wine near the nuptial bed. C. --- In me. Heb. "he brought me to the banquetting-house, and his banner over me was love." Prot. H. --- He has shewn me the greatest tenderness. Only the religion of Christ lays before us our duties to God, to ourselves, and neighbours. C. S. Tho. ii. 2. q. 26. H. --- The holy Spirit came on the assembled disciples, who were deemed to be drunk, and Christ nourishes the pious soul with the wine of his own blood. M.

Ver. 5. Flowers. Heb. "bottles." --- Languish. Sept. "am wounded." H. -- Those who enter upon the paths of virtue, are often deprived of consolations. C. ---

They must support themselves by reflecting on the words and sufferings of Christ. S. Amb. ps. cxviii. ser. 5. Boss.

Ver. 6. Hand. After peace comes affliction: grace is followed by glory. Prov. iii.

16. C.

Ver. 7. I. Christ permits not his Church to be persecuted, till she be able to bear it. W. --- Roes.

Sept. "armies and power;" the angels and apostles, who have spread the gospel through the world.

It would seem that the Jewish women loved hunting, (C.) like those of Phœnicia and Lacedæmon.

Æneid. i. They were going to sing, (C.) the morning epithalamium, (Theocrit.

xviii.) after the first night of the marriage. The second meeting takes place, v. 8.

17. H.

Ver. 8. The. Feeling the protection of Christ, the Church preacheth boldly the truth against pagans and heretics. W. --- She knows the voice of the shepherd, (Jo. viii. 47. and x. 2.) and keeps at a distance the wolves in sheep's clothing, or pretended reformers, who would scatter the flock. --- Hills. She sees him returning in the evening with the utmost speed of a stag, as the Heb.

implies. C. ii. 9. and viii. 14.

Ver. 9. Hart, (Prov. v. 18.) which is swifter than the dogs. Xenoph. Cuneg. --- This animal is said to destroy serpents, as Christ did the power of the devil. Theod.

--- Wall. Under the old law, Christ was only seen in figure. He manifested himself in the new. Yet our sins separate him from us. Is. lix. 2. He is concealed in the sacred mysteries, (C.) and his humanity keeps from our sight the glory of his divinity, which alone can impart full content. S. Amb. S. Bern. --- He shewed a glimpse of it at his transfiguration, and by his miracles. M.

Ver. 10. Arise. He sings under the window, to v. 16. --- My dove, is taken from the Sept. C. ---

Christ invites his spouse to approach, though he shews not himself as yet; and orders his pastors to root out heresies. v. 25. W. --- She is ever faithful, and rejoices in him. 2 Cor. xi. 2. Matt. ix.

15. Eph. v. 26. C.

Ver. 11. Winter. The rigour and darkness of the old law give place to that of light and love. Orig.

**--- After persecution had ceased, pruning became more necessary. C. ---
The Israelites and the world were redeemed in spring, and the ceremonies of the law were abolished at the same season.**

M.

Ver. 12. Pruning. Prot. "singing of birds. " H. --- But the former version is better.

Sept. Sym.

&c. --- Turtle. Which returns in spring. Is. viii. 9. C. --- It denotes the preaching of the gospel, (S. Cyr. ador. 15.) or rather the sighs of a holy soul in exile.

Ver. 14. Rock. Wild pigeons retire thither. Varro, iii. 7. Koilen eiseptato petren.

Il. 20. Ser.

xlvi. 28. C. --- Holy souls seek protection in the wounds of their Saviour. S.

Greg. S. Bern. ser.

lxi. --- Wall. In the holy Scriptures, which defend the Church. She is brought to light for the edification of all. M.

Ver. 15. Foxes. They hurt vines, (Theoc. 5.) and denote false prophets. Ezec.

xiii. 4. S. Aug.

Ps. lxxx. --- For. Heb. "and our vines of Semadar." v. 13. C. --- Foxes breed in spring, and greatly infested the country. Judg. xv. 4.

Ver. 16. Feedeth. "His flock." Sept. He still retains the fragranciness of lilies. As married people are two in one flesh, (Eph. v. 31.) Christ and his Church are irrevocably united. C. --- She reposes in him. W.

Ver. 17. Break. Or "yield a refreshing air," (aspiret) in the morning, (H.) and evening, when she begs he will return, (Theod.) as she could not enjoy his company in the day-time. C. i. 1. and iv.

6. --- Bether. Or the lower Bethoron, near Jerusalem. These short visits in the night, shew the vicissitudes of comfort and dryness in the most perfect. Those who are still addicted to their passions, and to the world, can have no pretensions to such favours, which amply repay any passing desolation. S.

Bern. ser. lxxiv. C.

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Bed. The Church, finding Christ by his own revelation, and not by philosophy, holds him fast. W. --- He had delayed coming at the usual hour, to give us to understand, that he is not found amid delights, nor in a crowd, but that we must seek him diligently, like Magdalene. Jo.

xx. S. Amb. de Isaac. --- The apostles endeavoured to convert the synagogue, but their offers were rejected, and the guards, or princes, persecuted them. M.

C. v. 7. H.

Ver. 3. City. To prevent fires, &c. God will require the souls of the flock at the hands of his pastors.

Ver. 4. Me. She was perhaps dead. Women had separate apartments, to which none but the husband could have access. Gen. xxiv. 28. At the end of the marriage-feast, the bride was conducted to her husband's house. Matt. xxv. 1.

C. --- The Jews shall in the end acknowledge Christ, (W.) as the Church desires. M.

Ver. 5. I. The bridegroom (C.) speaks as c. ii. 7. (W.) and c. viii. 4. He retires early.

Ver. 6. Who. The female companions of the spouse, (C.) or the bridegroom's friends, (M.) admire her at a distance. C. vi. 9. and viii. 5. **C. ---** The converted Gentiles change the desert of the world into a paradise, by their good works, which ascend like a perfume. S. Greg. They admire their own conversion, and proclaim that we must fight for heaven, (W.) and adore Christ, the God-man; imitating all his virtues, (H.) and preaching his gospel. M.

Ver. 7. Bed. Being stationed at the door to prevent any alarm, v. 8. **C. ---** In the Church Christ finds his repose, and daily produces the only heirs of heaven.

Ven. Bede. --- The angels, saints and pastors watch to defend it against the spirits of darkness. M.

Ver. 9. Litter. Sept. to conduct his spouse with solemnity; or a throne; though it most probably denotes the bridal bed. **C. ---** Heb. apiron. Greek, φορειον.

Ver. 10. Going. Prot. "covering of it of purple." H. --- Death must be endured, if necessary, for the sake of the faith, as this is the highest degree of charity. W.

--- He, &c. Heb. "is prepared for the beloved above the," &c. See Od. v. 660. C.

--- Prot. and Pagn. "the midst thereof being paved (Mont. set on fire) with love for (Mont. by) the daughters." H. --- The most desirable things adorn the litter, or the Church, that all may come to her, who has God to guide her decisions.

M.

Ver. 11. Go. All are invited to come to Christ, who, in his sacred humanity, which he took of his mother, was crowned in heaven, after his passion. W. S.

Greg. Alcuin. --- The synagogue crowned him with thorns, and gave him the hard bed of the cross. S. Bern. S. Anselm, &c. ---

Bethsabee might live to see the marriage of her son, who owed the crown to her. 3 K. i. 18.

Prov. iv. 3. Both the parties were crowned, (Is. lxi. 10.) and no doubt Solomon would display his usual magnificence. The diadem was a bandage, adorned with embroidery, and precious stones.

C.

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. How. Christ again praises the beauty of his Church. W. --- The dialogue takes place in the country. H. --- From corporal beauty, which is often dangerous, and the portion of the most dissolute, we must raise our minds to spiritual advantages, which the Holy Ghost has here in view. --- Within. S. Amb.

"besides thy taciturnity." Sept. "silence." Rabbins, &c. "hair." Prot.

"within thy locks." But what renders this version of tsammathec (H.) suspicious is, that none of the ancients knew of it, and the hair is afterwards specified. C. vi. 4. Moreover, Isaias, (xlvii. 2.) uses it for (C.) "turpitude," (S.

Jer.) or the parts which are usually "covered." Sept. H. --- Si qua latent, meliora putat. Met. 1500. --- All the glory of the king's daughter is within. Ps. xlv. 14.

Modesty and silence are the best encomium. C. --- The Lord praises the intention, occupations and doctrine of the Church, the twins of faith and good works; the preaching of Christ's passion without shame, (v. 3.) and the administration of the sacraments, which, like the neck, unite the members to their head; so that they become invincible, (v. 4.) whether they be of Jewish or Gentile extraction, v. 5. W. --- Up. Heb. and Sept. "appear." Jerusalem was the highest part of the country; (H.) and coming up and down often means no more than coming or going. Jug. xi. 3.

and xv. 11. C. --- The hair of goats in Lycia was beautifully curled. Ælian xvi. 30.

--- Women used such false hair. Mart. xii. 45. --- Though the hair be only an ornament, it is not to be neglected; so the pious Christian will always treat with respect the ceremonies established chiefly for the instruction of the ignorant.

C. --- Those simple and fervent souls, by their numbers, adorn the Church, as hair does the body. S. Greg. --- The external and internal perfections of the spouse deserve commendation. M.

Ver. 2. Them. Those who lay aside the old man, and receive baptism, are filled with grace, to bring forth the fruits of virtue. S. Aug. Doct. ii. 6. --- Pastors in particular, must lay aside worldly cares, and attend to their flocks. M.

Ver. 3. Scarlet. Preachers of the gospel (S. Greg.) must speak with elegance, and have their lips dyed with the blood of Christ, and purified with coals from the altar. C. --- So, if we may use the words of a living critic, who is sometimes accurate, "a commentator ought to study at the foot of his crucifix, and write with ink drawn from the heart of Jesus." H. --- Pomegranate. Plump and ruddy, representing the purity of the Church, and of virgins, who are its "flower," (S.

Cyp.) and bring forth fruits of good works. S. Aug. de Virg.

Ver. 4. Bulwarks. Heb. Thalpiyoth, "at the height of the defiles," probably in Libanus, when David conquered Syria. Thalassar, Thelmela, &c. were such

"heights." Bucklers, to be used in case of need, or for ornament. Thus the neck of the spouse was adorned with chains and pearls.

The Church is this tower, the pillar of truth, 1 Tim. iii. Matt. xvi. 18. Apostles and prelates are her bucklers.

Ver. 5. Roes. This comparison does not seem happy: but exactitude is not required. C. --- Indeed if we were to take all in the literal sense, a very grotesque figure would arise, with a head like Carmel, a nose like a tower, &c.

which shews that the tropological or allegorical sense must be adopted. D. ---

The two Testaments given for our instruction, (c. i. 2.) or the charity towards God and our neighbour, may be meant. Theod.

Ver. 6. Retire. In the morning, (Sanct.) or rather the bridegroom takes his leave early, promising to return in the evening. C. ii. 17. C. --- Myrrh. To Calvary, where the fervent will pour forth their prayers, and learn mortification. C. ---

Christ dwells in mortified and devout minds.

Ver. 7. Thee. All must be pure before they enter heaven, as the blessed Virgin was on earth, (W.) and the Church is still. Eph. v. 27. C. --- Before his departure, Christ heaps praises on her.

Ver. 8. Thou. Heb. "look from." --- Libanus. So Jerusalem is called, Zac. xi. 3.

Ribera. M. ---

Amana. Sept. "faith." By it and charity, we must do good. S. Aug. Ps. lxvii.

Amanus separates Cilicia from Syria. --- Sanir is the name given by the Phenicians to Hermon, (Eusebius) beyond the Jordan. 1 Par. v. 23. ---

Leopards. It is not fit for women to hunt such beasts. Ovid (Met. x.

10.) thus speaks of Venus: Nuda genu, vestemque ritu succincta Dianæ, &c.

The Church leaves Jerusalem to preach the gospel without fear. M.

Ver. 9. Wounded. Symmachus, "given." Sept. Prot. "ravished." Mystic writers suppose, that the spouse had been guilty of some negligence; or, on the contrary, that her deportment was most enchanting, bent on God, and on good works. C. --- Sister. So Assuerus styles himself brother of Esther. xv. 12. Christ died for the unity of his Church. M.

Ver. 10. Spices. He returns her compliment. C. i. 2.

Ver. 11. Lips. Teachers who accommodate their instructions to the capacity of their audience, (C.) giving milk to children. Heb. v. 13. H. 1 Cor. iii. 2. --- In allusion, perhaps, to this passage, (C.) it was customary to give milk and honey to the new baptized. Tert. coron. --- Garments.

Which were perfumed, (Gen. xxvii. 17. Ps. xlv. 9.) and imply good works, (2

Cor. v. 3. Rom.

xiii. 14. C.) and the external service and prayers of the Church, which ascend like incense. Ps.

cxl. 2. M.

Ver. 12. Up. She is perfectly chaste. Prov. v. 14. The Church excludes from her society all unbelievers and schismatics. The wicked serve to exercise the virtuous. Her pastors explain the Scriptures, the fountains of saving knowledge. C. --- Christ is also a fountain. Zac. xiii. 1. and Jo. vii. 37. M.

Ver. 13. Plants. The various orders of clergy and laity. --- Cyprus, (c. i. 13. C.) whence a healing oil is extracted. Theod. --- Prot. "camphire." H. --- Spikenard is twice mentioned, as it may be well mixed with cyprus and saffron. M.

Ver. 14. Cinnamon. Very rare. Ex. xxx. 23. --- Libanus, or "incense." Heb.

Ver. 15. Libanus. The law of the gospel was proclaimed by the apostles, who were Jews. They explained the pure doctrine of the Scriptures, and converted many.

Ver. 16. Wind. At different times. Let all nations be convinced of thy beauty. C.

--- The holy Spirit enabled the apostles to convert the world. Nys. Rupert. --- All temptations, whether proceeding from cruelty or deceit, "make constant souls more grateful to God." W.

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. Apple-trees. The spouse, submitting to God's will, is content to suffer.

W. --- She addresses her beloved, and as he had praised her, under the similitude of a delightful garden, she invites him into it. C. --- I, &c. Christ again approves of her patience, and invites the saints to congratulate with her. W. ---

He always hears his Church. Matt. xxviii. 20. Mark xi. 24. C. ---

The saints had prayed for Christ's coming; and, accordingly, (Is. lviii. 9.) he takes flesh of the most pure virgin. S. Athan. Synop. --- Comb. Sept. "bread."

--- Milk. Chal. "white wine." But (C.) milk and wine may be taken together.

Clem. Pæd. i. 6. --- The chaste delights of retired and penitent souls are thus described: (C.) *Dulciores sunt lacrymæ orantium quam gaudia theatrorum*. S.

Aug. Ps. cxxviii. "The tears of penitents are the wine of angels, because in them is the odour of life." S. Bern. ser. 30. --- Inebriated. Not so as to lose reason. Gen. xliii. 34. C.

--- Prot. marg. "be drunk with loves." H. Prov. v. 19. and vii. 18. This wine of love, is the blessed Eucharist, which maketh virgins to spring forth, (Zac. ix.

17.) and is a foretaste of heaven.

Ps. xxxv. 9. It makes us forget the old man, (C.) and raise the mind to God. S.

Cyp. ep. 63. --- To this feast Christ invites his disciples. Matt. xxvi. and 1 Cor.

xi. M. --- Myrrh. Implies that they must be mortified. H.

Ver. 2. Knocking. The spouse had retired to rest, as her beloved delayed longer than usual. But love is ever on the watch. C. --- She wished to meditate, but is called upon to assist others, and excited by Christ's own example. W. --- Dew.

Having been out in the evening, preceding this fourth night. This denotes imperfect Christians, who remain, indeed, attached to the head, but are a disgrace to it, by their scandalous lives. S. Aug. tr. 37 in Jo. S. Greg. C. --- Such was the state of many in the days of Luther, who accordingly joined the first reformers. See Philips's Life of Card. Pole. p. 364. H. --- Nights. Anacreon (ode 1.) has something similar. Christ knocks by his inspirations and chastisements, and he is better heard in the night of tribulation. Apoc. iii. 20. C.

--- Heretics began to blaspheme Christ, after the Church had only enjoyed a short peace, (M.) after the ten persecutions.

Ver. 3. Garment. By this is designated the tunic, which was undermost. H. ---

Feet. People in that climate had their feet bare in the house, and even on journies only wore sandals: so that frequent washing was requisite. Gen. xviii.

4. and 1 Tim. v. 10. These excuses were vain, and Christ would not regard them. Matt. xxv. 1. Lu. xii. 35. Theod. C. --- The care of souls brings on many external occupations, which contemplative men would decline. S. Greg. M.

Ver. 4. Touch. Of me, (Cassiod.) or rather of the door or window. I was grieved that I had made him wait so long. C. --- Heb. "were moved for him." Prot. marg.

"or (as some read) in me."

Pagnin prefers this; Sept. and Mont. the former explanation of halaiv. H. ---

Grace moves us to begin and prosecute good works. S. Greg. Nyssen. Theod.

--- Christ gives it more abundantly, to make the champions of the Church contend with adversity. M.

Ver. 5. Arose. The Church employs herself in active life, still retaining a desire to return to contemplation. v. 8. W.

Ver. 8. Love. She seems insensible to the insults received. C. --- The Church prays to the saints on earth, and in heaven. M.

Ver. 10. Ruddy. Or shining. Et color in niveo corpore purpureus. The divine and human nature, or the conception and sufferings of Christ are thus described.

C. --- The spouse gives this admirable description of her beloved. H.

Ver. 11. Gold. God is the head of Christ, (1 Cor. xi. 3.) and is most pure. N. ---

The guards of Solomon were powdered with gold dust. Jos. Ant. --- Branches.

Elataë, or fruits of the male palm-tree. Theod. Plin. xiii. 4.

Ver. 13. Set by. Prot. " as sweet flowers." --- Choice. Lit. "the first." v. 5. H. ---

The modesty and words of Christ excited admiration. 1 Pet. ii. 21. Jo. vii. 46. C.

--- He exhorted sinners to repent, and rebuked the obstinate. M.

Ver. 14. Hyacinths. Or purple veins. C. --- Prot. "hands are as gold rings set with the beryl."

Heb. "full of Tharsis," (H.) or precious stones, (M.) from that country, (Ex.

xxviii.) with which his rings were ornamented. C. --- Sapphires. His belt or garment is thus ornamented. Sanchez.

--- The works of Christ proceeded from his infinite charity for mankind, whose salvation he greatly desired, (Mar. vii. 37. and 1 Cor. xv. 22. and 1 Tim. ii. 4.) so that none can perish but by their own fault. C.

Ver. 16. Lovely. Heb. and Sept. " desires. " M. --- The beauty of Christ is chiefly interior; and all must aim at this perfection, who would be his spouses. Ps.

xliv. 3. C.

**Ver. 17. Seek. The fervent resolve to seek Christ, wherever he may be.
W. ---**

His praises excite many to love him. M.

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 1. Lilies. The church teaches, that God is delighted with the pious desires and works of the faithful. W. --- She answers the question which had been put to her. C. --- God associates lilies, or the perfect, to his angels. He "feeds his flock," and "is fed," on works of piety, as Heb. and Sept. imply both. M.

Ver. 2. Beloved. She speaks thus, when she finds him, and runs to his embraces, having found what trouble her neglect had occasioned. C.

Ver. 3. Thou. Christ again commends his Church, which is well composed of distinct orders, some governing, others retired from the world, and the rest exercising works of mercy, amid its troubles, who altogether form a complete army, terrible to all her enemies. W. --- Jerusalem.

Which was then one of the finest cities in the east. C. The Catholic Church resembles the heavenly Jerusalem. Theod. --- Terrible. So great is the power of love, (Rom. viii. 35.) in the martyrs, and of the Church, against infidels! C. ---

She is lovely to Christ, and terrible to the wicked. Even her spouse is wounded by her glance. M.

Ver. 4. Turn. The more one contemplates God's majesty, the more he will be convinced that it is incomprehensible. W. --- To pry into mysteries, may cause Christ to retire. Theod. &c.

Ver. 7. Number. The true pastors are numerous, but hirelings more so. The faithful are innumerable, and all are united in the same faith. W. --
- The spouse and the queens represent the more perfect; the concubines, or wives of inferior degree, those who are led by fear; and the maidens, such as are languid and negligent. Orig. --- The Roman Church is at the head of all metropolitan, episcopal, and parochial Churches. H.

Ver. 9. Who. The companions of the spouse, (C.) or the synagogue, admire the Christian Church.

W. --- Morning. Aurora. The Church dissipated the darkness of paganism; she appeared as the moon under persecution, and as the sun, after the conversion of Constantine. C. --- The like will happen in the days of antichrist. Ven. Bede.

--- The religion of the patriarchs may be compared to the morning-star: that of Moses, to the moon; and of Christ, to the sun. M.

Ver. 11. Aminadab. The devil, (Theod.) or probably some renowned general.

Aquila explains it

"of the people's leader," (C.) or "munificent one." Mont. --- I knew not what forced me to flee with such speed, as if I had been panic-struck, (C.) or the spouse professes that she knew not that he had retired into the garden of nuts, or she would not have been under apprehensions of his being ill-treated by Aminadab, as Christ was by Pilate. M.

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 1. What? Christ commends the Jews, who shall at last embrace the faith with great fervour.

W. --- Thou. Heb. and Sept. "ye." They join this sentence with the preceding chapter. H. ---

Companies. Heb. "as it were the choir (or dance) of Mahanaim," (C). where Jacob saw the camps of angels, near the Jaboc. H. Gen. xxxii. --- These dances might be proverbial.

Ver. 4. Ivory. Preachers communicate the sentiments of the Church, (C.) which prevails against the gates of hell. Cassiod.

Ver. 5. Carmel. Shaded with trees. C. --- Heb. "purple," which colour was sometimes given to the hair. Propert. ii. 18. --- Channels. Of the dyers. Heb. "to beams." C. --- Prot. "the king is held in the galleries" to view thee. H. --- Christ was all charity, and the faithful are twice dyed, with the love of God, and of their neighbour. M.

Ver. 7. Grapes. The Church triumphs over her adversaries, and feeds her children. C.

Ver. 8. Up. Christ shed his blood on the cross, and enabled his Church, composed of Jews and Gentiles, who were before barren, to produce a numerous progeny. C. --- Mouth. Heb. and Sept.

"nose."

Ver. 9. Lips. Sept. "sufficient for my lips and teeth." H. --- The wine in that country was very thick, when kept a long time. It here denotes charity, or the gospel truths. Lu. v. 37. Acts ii. 13.

Heb. "causing the lips of them who sleep to speak," (C.) as the apostles did, in transports of zeal.

Theod. --- Yet the reading of the Sept. Aquila, &c. seems preferable. C.

Ver. 10. Turning. The Church is submissive to Jesus Christ, and is entirely actuated by the Spirit.

C. --- She takes the words, as it were out of his mouth, (v. 9.) and answers, worthy, &c.

acknowledging that all the praise belongs to him.

Ver. 11. Villages. She begs that he would come and remain with her. W. --- She accompanies him into the country, on the morning after the fifth night. There Christ affords the purest delights, (v. 12. C.) and the Church (M.) becomes his mother, while she instructs and feeds others. S.

Greg. hom. M.

Ver. 13. Mandrakes. Heb. dodai comes from the same root as dodi, "my breasts or loves." v. 12.

H. --- It may denote oranges, as mandrakes are not spring-fruits. Gen. xxx. 14.

C. --- Yet (H.) married women eagerly sought after mandrakes. Here they may signify such as are fit to gain souls to Christ. M. --- And the old. Or great abundance. Lev. xxvi. 10. Matt. xiii. 52. C. --- She acknowledges Christ to be the Saviour of all, under the Old and the New Testament. W. --- A doctor of the Church shews Christ in the prophets, and figures of the law, as well as manifested in the gospel. Aponius, &c. C.

CANTICLE OF CANTICLES 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 1. Mother. The synagogue continues to pray for Christ's coming.

W. --- Her request has been heard, and He has assumed our nature; so that we may receive from him all the marks of tenderness, and none but the carnal will shew any signs of contempt. The spouse wishes to manifest her love without restraint, and to be delivered from the shame of sterility, (C.) or the Church desires to see Christ in heaven, and to praise him. M.

Ver. 2. Teach me economy, on which subject Xenophon represents the newly married entertaining themselves. --- Wine. Mar. xv. 23. Os. xiv. 8. Nectar was of this description, (C.) being composed of wine, honey, and odoriferous flowers.

The best was made at Babylon. Athen.

i. 25. and ii. 2. --- These liquors intimate all the virtues, which Christ has taught; the practice of which affords him the greatest satisfaction. Jo. xiv. 23.

They are best learnt in retirement, (C.) and from our great teacher. Mic. iv. 2. M.

Ver. 4. Jerusalem. Sept. add, "by the armies and powers of the field," as c. ii. 7.

and iii. 5. H. ---

The spouse presently awakes after the sixth night, and goes out. C. --- Christ admonishes all not to disturb those who would serve him. W.

Ver. 5. Flowing. Thus speak the companions of the spouse; and the bridegroom, turning to her alone, reminds her of an adventure. The Jews would put this in the mouth of the spouse. C. ---

Corrupted. Heb. and Sept. "fell in labour, there she was delivered who bore thee." H. --- Christ redeemed Eve, who had been seduced to eat the forbidden fruit, and by his sacred blood on the cross, awoke and healed our fallen nature. C. --- The court of heaven admires the Church of the Gentiles, and every pious soul ascending from this world, particularly the blessed Virgin.

The synagogue was corrupt, when she called for the death of the Son of God, and said, His blood be upon us, &c. We have no king but Cæsar. W. --- Grace must go before, that our free-will may also walk forward. M.

Ver. 6. Arm. Working by charity. Gal. v. 6. H. --- Women in the east imprint what they like most on their bosom and arms, or carry bracelets and gems on those parts, with similar inscriptions. Os. ii. 2. Is. iii. 20. S. Clem. Pæd. ii. 11. --- Christ must live in us. C. --- Tota ejus species exprimatur in nobis. S. Amb. Isaac viii.

--- Jealousy. That is, zealous and burning love.

Ch. --- Hell. Or the grave, which subdues all. Love is a violent passion. C. ---

Nullus liber erit, si quis amare velit. Prop. ii. --- Christ gave his life to redeem mankind, and the martyrs have joyfully endured torments and death, to evince their love. C. --- Flames. Heb. "a flame of God,"

or most vehement. H.

Ver. 7. Drown it. As other fires may be extinguished. He who sinks under persecution, has not real charity. Temptation does not weaken a person, but shews what he is. Eccclus. xxxiv. 9. C. ---

He shall. Worldlings will ridicule his parting with temporal delights, for those which do not appear: but the true lover will make no account of the former. C.

Ver. 8. Our sister. Christ styles the Church his own and the synagogue's sister, promising her many benefits. W. --- The relations of the spouse wish to have her married, though she seemed young. Ezec. xvi. 7. --- Spoken to, concerning marriage, or its consummation. Gen. xxxiv. 6.

Dan. xiii. 57. C. --- The synagogue had but few to give her proper instructions.

M. --- But Christ would provide her, if she were not wanting to herself. H.

Ver. 9. Cedar. Procuring for her a rich and steady husband to protect her.

These are the words of the bridegroom. The Christian Church seemed weak at first. But her pastors and martyrs caused her to triumph over all the powers of hell. C. --- Those who correspond with the first grace, are furnished with others. M.

Ver. 11. The. The bridegroom, in the character of a countryman, asserts that he would not give his vineyard or spouse (C.) for all the king's riches.

Ver. 12. Before me. I am satisfied with my spouse. --- The peaceable. Heb. and Sept.

"Solomon." H. --- Retain them, and also pay the keepers their wages. I envy not all the treasures of the world; nor would put them in competition with my vineyard, or spouse. The synagogue of Moses and Solomon degenerated, while the Church of Christ has continued faithful, and has always some good workmen. S. Greg. Ven. Bede, &c. C.

Ver. 13. Hearken. The seventh morning is come, and I must depart to the mountains. C. ii. 17.

and iv. 6. Christ, before his ascension, exhorts his Church to present her petitions. He is always ready to hear her, and to grant her aid, in every emergency. See S. Amb. de Virg. xvi. 99. --- The virtuous pray that her requests may be granted, (H.) and are eager to know what they are. M.

Ver. 14. Flee. The Church consents that her beloved should ascend to heaven, as he still remains with her. Ven. Bede. S. Bern. ser. ix. Qui habitat. C. --- The whole Church militant requests that he would ascend thither, for the good of all his servants, begging for an abundant supply of grace, that we may ascend the high mountains of perfect charity, and zeal for God's honour; and that he would make our souls such hills and gardens, adorned with all the flowers and fruits of virtue, in which he may vouchsafe to dwell. Amen. W. --- Flee to heaven, and draw me with thee. C. i. 4. M.